forward. Some observers suggest that its 'move to the right has been a pragmatic step to try to gain a majority, by promising everything to everyone and making sure to bow to popular anti-Muslim sentiment'.[27] Indeed the MaBaTha has openly backed the USDP[28] on the grounds that the NLD opposed some of the recent anti-Muslim laws (in particular the ban on inter-communal marriages). Before the 2015 election, the NLD failed to break with its old allies despite this shift of allegiance, for fear of undermining its electoral appeal. This has led to the situation identified by Mark Farmaner of the Burma Campaign UK:

> I think [Aung San Suu Kyi] has seriously miscalculated her response to anti-Muslim violence in Burma, She has ended up with the worst of both worlds. On the one hand, she hasn't spoken up for an oppressed and endangered minority, on the other hand, she's still being attacked by the 969 Movement and losing support because there remains a perception that she's friendly to Muslims. Because she didn't take a firm moral stance against anti-Muslim feeling from the start, using her moral authority, she has opened the way for people like Wirathu to act with absolute impunity.[29]

There is strong evidence to suggest that Aung San Suu Kyi personally shares some of the views of the Buddhist hierarchy, which indicates that while she may be a prisoner of her allies she may not be so unhappy with the consequences. She wrote a short paper in 1985 praising the Burmese 'racial psyche' and claiming that Buddhism 'represents the perfected philosophy. It therefore follows that there [is] no need either to develop it further or to consider other philosophies'.[30] If those remain her views, then her silence over the persecution of the Rohingyas is not just a reflection of the pressures she faces, but an indication that there is at least some ambiguity in her position over the right of the Rohingyas to live in Myanmar.

This has affected the NLD's approach in two ways. In a sense it has joined in the consensus that the Rohingyas have no place in Myanmar. The NLD calculates that there is no political benefit to standing up for the Rohingyas, and it has not done so. Aung San Suu Kyi's spokesperson has even used the word 'Bengalis' to refer to Rohingyas, which indicates her public position. In addition, after the white card declaration in 2015 (which removed the final form of state identification held by the Rohingyas), the NLD, in compliance with a legal requirement, expelled about 20,000 members from the party in order to comply with the new law.[31] Many of these had joined the NLD in 2000 and held membership cards with